Literature Review: Exchange, Society, and the Himalayan Salt Economy

1.1 Introduction

Salt has occupied a distinctive place in human history. Essential for survival yet unevenly distributed across landscapes, it has shaped patterns of mobility, exchange, political authority, and social organisation across diverse societies. Historical research on salt has examined trade, taxation, state monopoly, and imperialism, highlighting salt's economic significance for subsistence and government revenue (Lally, 2021; Taylor, 2023). These studies have enhanced our understanding of salt as a strategic good, especially in colonial administration and distant trade. Understanding the historical significance of salt therefore requires moving beyond its material value and examining the social institutions that shaped its circulation.

This question is particularly relevant to the Himalayan region. The Western Himalayas, encompassing one of the world's most biodiverse mountain systems, were bounded by pastoral plateaus, agricultural valleys, monastic centres, and frontier markets, and within this complex cultural landscape existed an extensive network of seasonal exchange. Salt from the saline lakes of Changthang flowed with pashm, wool, grain, tea, livestock, and other merchandise to connect peoples who inhabited different ecological zones (Rizvi, 1996, pp. 97–103). The Tibetan and Himalayan salt trade has attracted growing scholarship, and this chapter reviews these strands and their significance. Historians have generally focused on the structure of the salt trade, while anthropologists pay close attention to the details of everyday economic exchange and exchange systems, particularly floral extraction, pastoral mobility, and the spatial and social dimension of *netsang*. This scholarship has shed light on the ancient trans-Himalayan trade. It is also valuable to consider how this trade has been transformed in the 19th and 20th centuries, through colonial rule, assimilation, and taxation.

Theoretical perspectives developed within anthropology, economic history and social theory provide an important framework for interpreting these historical processes. During the twentieth century scholars increasingly challenged the assumption that markets represented the universal basis of economic life. Marcel Mauss argued that early modes of exchange were based on reciprocity, not contract, while Karl Polanyi explained that non-market economies were embedded within other social institutions and were not isolated market systems. Following in this tradition, James C. Scott and E. P. Thompson explored the moral aspects of economic behaviour, stressing the significance of custom, subsistence values, and conceptions of justice among common people's reactions to political and economic transformations. More recently, scholars like Prasannan Parthasarathi pointed out that markets were constructed politically during colonial times, arguing that capitalism was a product of state intervention in history, and not a development from prior forms of economic organisation. These perspectives offer a conceptual framework for viewing exchange as an institution, not only an economic process.

To establish the conceptual basis for analysing the Himalayan salt economy, this chapter relies on these theories. Instead of providing a comprehensive analysis of each scholar's work separately, this chapter synthesises the key debates about exchange, embedded economies, moral economy, and colonial transformation of exchange systems, to place these debates within Himalayan historiography. It does not seek to force a theory upon historiography but identifies concepts that help explain the economy of salt production, exchange, and trade in the Himalayas.

The chapter is organised into three substantive sections. The first focuses on the literature of gift-exchange systems as studied by Marcel Mauss and Karl Polanyi, and their rejection of the market-centred view of economic life. The second reviews debates on moral economy and colonial transformation, drawing upon the contributions of James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi to examine how embedded systems of exchange were reshaped under colonial capitalism. The third section examines Himalayan historiography and studies the historiography and anthropology of salt, its ecological setting, and social formations within it.

1.2 Exchange Before Markets and the Embedded Economy

How societies organised production and exchange before market capitalism is a central question in economic anthropology. Challenging classical economic assumptions about individual rationality and market exchange, Mauss and Polanyi approached this question by examining the obligations and institutions through which societies secured their material livelihoods.

Marcel Mauss' The Gift marked a decisive departure from earlier evolutionary theories that interpreted exchange as a progression from barter to markets. Rather than asking how commercial exchange developed, Mauss sought to understand why gifts, which appeared voluntary, generated enduring obligations between individuals and communities. His answer altered anthropological understandings of exchange. Gifts, he argued, were never simple transfers of property. They constituted "total social facts" in which economic activity remained inseparable from legal obligations, religious beliefs, political authority, moral expectations, and collective identity (Mauss, 2002, Introduction).

Mauss' formulation holds that gift exchange rests on three mutually reinforcing obligations: the obligation to give, the obligation to receive, and the obligation to reciprocate (Mauss, 2002, chs 1–2). These obligations transformed exchange from an act of individual generosity into a mechanism through which social relationships were continually reproduced. Refusing to give represented a failure of social responsibility; refusing to receive rejected the relationship offered by the giver; while accepting without reciprocating resulted in a loss of honour and social standing. Exchange was therefore governed not by contractual enforcement or monetary calculation but by reciprocal obligation and collective recognition. Wealth acquired value through

circulation rather than accumulation, and prestige depended upon an individual's or community's capacity to participate in these reciprocal relationships.

Mauss illustrates these principles through the institution of the Potlatch among the Indigenous societies of the north-west coast of North America. During these elaborate ceremonial gatherings, chiefs distributed, consumed, and sometimes deliberately destroyed significant quantities of wealth before assembled communities. Judged according to modern economic rationality, such practices appear wasteful and economically irrational. Yet Mauss demonstrates that their significance lay precisely in their capacity to establish political authority, social prestige, and collective legitimacy. Wealth was accumulated to be given away, and generosity itself functioned as a source of power (Mauss, 2002, ch. 2).

Mauss' concept of *hau* or *mana* concerns the spiritual essence that lived in the object of exchange in Polynesia. For example, the gift was not considered a mere commodity detachable from its owner, but an item containing the essence of the giver, making the receiver accountable through continuing obligations (Mauss, 2002, ch. 1). Failure to reciprocate therefore represented more than economic indebtedness. It disrupted relationships that were simultaneously social, religious, and political.

Although Mauss convincingly established the social foundations of exchange, his analysis primarily concerned the circulation of gifts and the obligations generated between exchange partners. Karl Polanyi extended this insight by asking a broader question: if exchange was socially embedded, how were entire economies organised before the emergence of market society? His contribution shifted attention from individual acts of reciprocity to the institutional organisation of economic life, thereby providing a more comprehensive critique of market universalism.

Polanyi's distinction between formalist and substantivist economics is one of the most influential interventions in twentieth-century economic anthropology. Formalist economics defines economic activity as rational choice under conditions of scarcity and therefore assumes that market behaviour provides a universal model for analysing all societies. Polanyi rejected this assumption by arguing that such a definition reflects the historically specific conditions of capitalist economies rather than the organisation of economic life more generally. In its substantive sense, the economy refers simply to the institutional processes through which societies secure their material livelihoods (Polanyi, 1957, pp. 243–250).

Whereas Mauss focuses on the social obligations generated by gift exchange, Polanyi examines the institutional organisation of economies as a whole. Within this broader framework, Polanyi identified reciprocity, redistribution, and householding as the principal forms through which pre-market societies organised production and circulation. Reciprocity involved exchanges among socially affiliated groups under enduring obligations; redistribution entailed the collection of goods at politically or religiously centralised locations and their subsequent allocation throughout society; and householding centred on production for the collective needs of a relatively self-sufficient group. Markets certainly existed, but they remained subordinate to these wider institutional arrangements rather than regulating society itself (Polanyi, 2001, ch. 4).

These perspectives provide an important conceptual foundation for understanding historical exchange in frontier regions such as the Himalayas. A simple market perspective is not enough to analyse the movement of goods over long distances, since these goods were often transported through institutions based on kinship relations, customary obligations, ecological interdependence, and political power. Exchange therefore represented not merely the movement of goods but the reproduction of wider social relationships that enabled communities to survive within challenging environmental and political landscapes. Yet embedded economies were neither static nor immune to historical change. The expansion of colonial states, the emergence of capitalist markets, and the increasing regulation of labour and resources gradually transformed these earlier systems of reciprocity and redistribution. Understanding this transformation requires moving beyond embedded exchange towards questions of moral economy, customary rights, and colonial political economy—issues that form the focus of the following section.

1.3 Moral Economy, Colonial Transformation, and the Making of Markets

The expansion of capitalist markets, the consolidation of state authority, and the restructuring of labour fundamentally altered earlier systems of reciprocity, redistribution, and customary exchange. Historians and political economists therefore examine how these pre-market societies saw the rise of market capitalism rather than the way in which pre-market societies operated. Central to this scholarship is the recognition that markets did not simply replace earlier forms of exchange through economic efficiency or technological progress. Rather, they were historically produced through political intervention, institutional restructuring, and changing relations of power. The writings of James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi have shaped this approach, although all of them study the problem from a different historical perspective.

James C. Scott’s concept of moral economy addresses subsistence and exchange. Writing primarily with reference to agrarian Southeast Asia, Scott challenged interpretations that viewed peasant behaviour as motivated principally by profit maximisation. Instead, he argued that subsistence constituted the central organising principle of peasant economic life. Communities operating close to ecological and economic margins sought above all to minimise risk rather than maximise returns. This "safety-first" principle shaped decisions concerning production, labour, and exchange, favouring stability over commercial opportunity (Scott, 1976, ch. 1). Economic choices therefore reflected the constant need to preserve subsistence rather than accumulate wealth.

Scott further argues that pre-capitalist societies were sustained by moral expectations that regulated relationships between rulers and subjects. Reciprocal obligations extended beyond local communities to include landlords, village elites, and political authorities, who were expected to protect the subsistence of those under their authority during periods of crisis.

Legitimacy therefore depended not simply upon legal sovereignty but upon adherence to widely recognised norms of reciprocity and social responsibility (Scott, 1976, chs 2 and 6). When these customary obligations were violated, whether through excessive taxation, inflexible revenue demands, or exploitative extraction, the resulting grievances were understood not merely as economic hardships but as breaches of an accepted moral order. Resistance consequently emerged not from abstract ideological commitments but from attempts to defend long-standing norms of subsistence and justice.

Although developed within a different historical setting, Scott's framework provides a valuable lens for interpreting frontier economies where livelihoods depended upon ecological uncertainty and seasonal exchange. Systems of reciprocity, customary obligation, and mutual assistance functioned not simply as cultural traditions but as practical mechanisms through which communities managed environmental risk. Thus, economic exchanges were linked with social security and contributed to the broader idea of Mauss and Polanyi that markets did not form the organising principles of pre-capitalist societies.

E. P. Thompson developed a related but distinct view and formulated the notion of moral economy through his research in eighteenth-century England. Like Mauss and Polanyi, Thompson dismissed purely economic explanations for the collective protests, stressing that such actions had more to do with traditional concepts of justice, rights, and legitimacy than just hunger. In his study of food riots, Thompson revealed that communities tended to preserve the traditional principles of distribution of vital resources, especially those challenged by market relations (Thompson, 1971, pp. 76–79). Markets, therefore, were experienced not simply as new economic institutions but as challenges to existing social relationships and collective understandings of justice.

Thompson's broader contribution lies in his insistence that historical change cannot be understood solely through quantitative measures of economic growth or material welfare. Distinguishing between a "standard of life" and a "way of life," he argues that processes of capitalist transformation frequently undermined customary institutions, communal practices, and forms of local autonomy even where material conditions appeared to improve (Thompson, 1963, ch. 6). This distinction directs attention towards forms of dispossession that remain invisible within conventional economic analysis. The erosion of customary authority, communal regulation, and locally embedded knowledge represents a transformation of social life that cannot be captured through indicators such as prices, wages, or output alone.

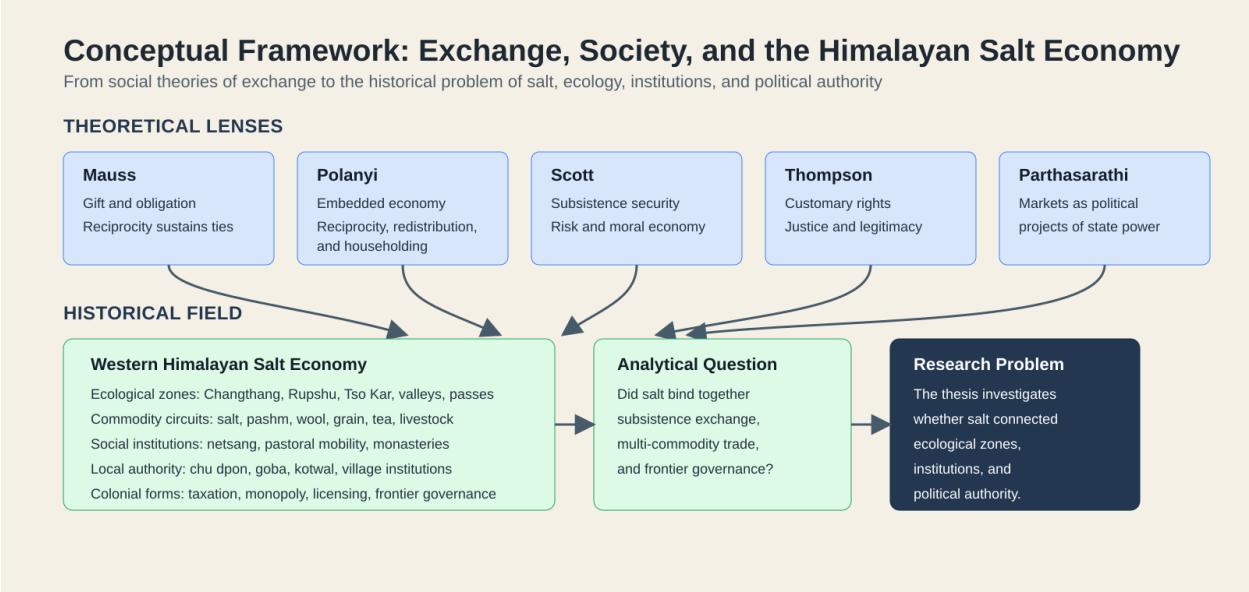
Where Scott highlights the subsistence ethic that underpinned agrarian communities, Thompson draws attention to the customary rights and communal institutions disrupted by expanding market relations. The transition towards capitalist markets consequently involved not merely the introduction of new forms of exchange but the reorganisation of social relationships that had previously regulated production, distribution, and access to resources. These debates have been extended by Prasannan Parthasarathi, whose work on labour, industry, and colonial political economy challenges narratives that portray capitalism as the inevitable outcome of European economic superiority. Examining South Asia within a global comparative framework, Parthasarathi argues that markets are neither autonomous nor historically inevitable. Instead,

they emerge through political decisions that reshape labour relations, production systems, and institutional structures. Colonial intervention therefore played a decisive role in reorganising existing economies, not by introducing markets into previously isolated societies, but by altering the conditions under which production and exchange were organised (Parthasarathi, 2001, pp. 1–10; 2011).

Parthasarathi's intervention shifts attention from exchange alone to the broader political economy of colonialism. The creation of new market relationships that favoured the interests of imperialism over the pre-existing systems of production was achieved through labour regimes, commerce, law, and the state.

Taken together, the works of Scott, Thompson, and Parthasarathi significantly deepen the insights offered by Mauss and Polanyi. While the latter demonstrate that pre-market exchange remained embedded within wider social institutions, the former explain how these institutions were progressively transformed through colonial intervention and the expansion of capitalist markets. Embedded economies were not simply displaced by more efficient market systems; they were reconfigured through changes in political authority, customary regulation, labour organisation, and state power.

These theories provide a framework for studying the Himalayan salt economy. The history of this region provides ample evidence that the system of exchanges was formed by traditional obligations, seasonal migrations, ecological cooperation, and local authorities before regulation through licences by colonial administrations. Understanding this transformation therefore requires not only a theory of embedded exchange but also an appreciation of how the colonial political economy restructured existing social institutions. The following section turns to the Himalayan historiography itself, examining how historians and anthropologists have interpreted the relationship between salt, ecology, and social formation across the Western Himalayas.



1.4 Salt, Ecology, and Himalayan Social Formation

Having established the theoretical foundations of exchange through embedded and moral economies, this section contextualises these debates through the history and ecology of the Western Himalayas. The existing literature on the salt economy of the Himalayas indicates that exchange in this region cannot be explained purely in terms of commodity circulation and commercial markets. Rather, historians and anthropologists have consistently shown that salt occupied a central position within a wider network of ecological adaptation, pastoral mobility, political authority, and social organisation. The Himalayan salt economy therefore provides an important empirical setting in which the theoretical perspectives discussed in the previous sections acquire historical significance.

Unlike many lowland commercial economies, the Western Himalayas were characterised by pronounced ecological diversity. High-altitude plateaus, cold arid deserts, fertile river valleys, and forested foothills each supported different forms of production. Whereas the regions of Changthang and Rupshu had vast amounts of saline water and practised pastoralism around sheep, goat, and yaks, the neighbouring valleys produced cereals, vegetables, and other agricultural produce. This environmental diversity created ecological complementarity in which no single region could remain economically self-sufficient. Instead, communities depended upon seasonal exchange to obtain resources unavailable within their own ecological zones. Trade offered commercial gains but was also a structural necessity for survival in this ecologically fragmented terrain.

Salt acquired particular significance in this environment. Historical studies of the Western Himalayas have repeatedly demonstrated that salt rarely circulated in isolation. Rather, it formed part of broader commodity circuits linking pashm, wool, barley, grain, tea, livestock, and other products exchanged between pastoral communities, agricultural settlements, monasteries, and regional markets (Rizvi, 1996, pp. 97–103). The movement of salt therefore reflected the

circulation of an interconnected economic system rather than the trade of a single commodity. As the project's central research framework argues, salt routes functioned as the infrastructural backbone of wider multi-commodity networks that connected the Tibetan Plateau with Ladakh, Kashmir, Baltistan, Himachal, and adjoining Himalayan regions.

Anthropological research also shows that these exchanges operated through social institutions rather than impersonal market transactions. An important social structure was *netsang*, a system of fictive kinship that created exchange partnerships between different families across ecological zones. Rather than negotiating each transaction independently, trading partners entered into durable relationships characterised by mutual trust, hospitality, and reciprocal obligation. These partnerships reduced uncertainty within environments where long-distance travel was constrained by altitude, climate, and political frontiers. Exchange therefore relied upon relationships that extended well beyond commercial calculation, reinforcing many of the theoretical observations advanced by Mauss and Polanyi regarding reciprocity and embedded exchange. Within the Himalayan context, commodities circulated because social relationships already existed; exchange did not create these relationships as much as it continually reaffirmed them.

The organisation of salt production itself likewise reflected the embedded character of the regional economy. Studies concerning the Rupshu-Tso Kar basin reveal that extraction was a highly controlled and seasonal activity based on customary institutions instead of individual property rights. Salt was collected during specific periods following seasonal evaporation, with labour organised collectively under locally recognised authorities (Ahmed, 1999, pp. 41–42). The duties of extraction, allocation, and transportation were assigned through village institutions, while access to the salt lakes was still based on customary management and was not left open for unrestricted exploitation. Administrative roles such as the chu dpon, *goba*, and *kotwal* coordinated the allocation of extraction areas, organised labour, and mediated disputes arising over access to common resources. These practices show that salt administration was part of the local political structure, which included political, ecological, and social functions instead of market-based property rights.

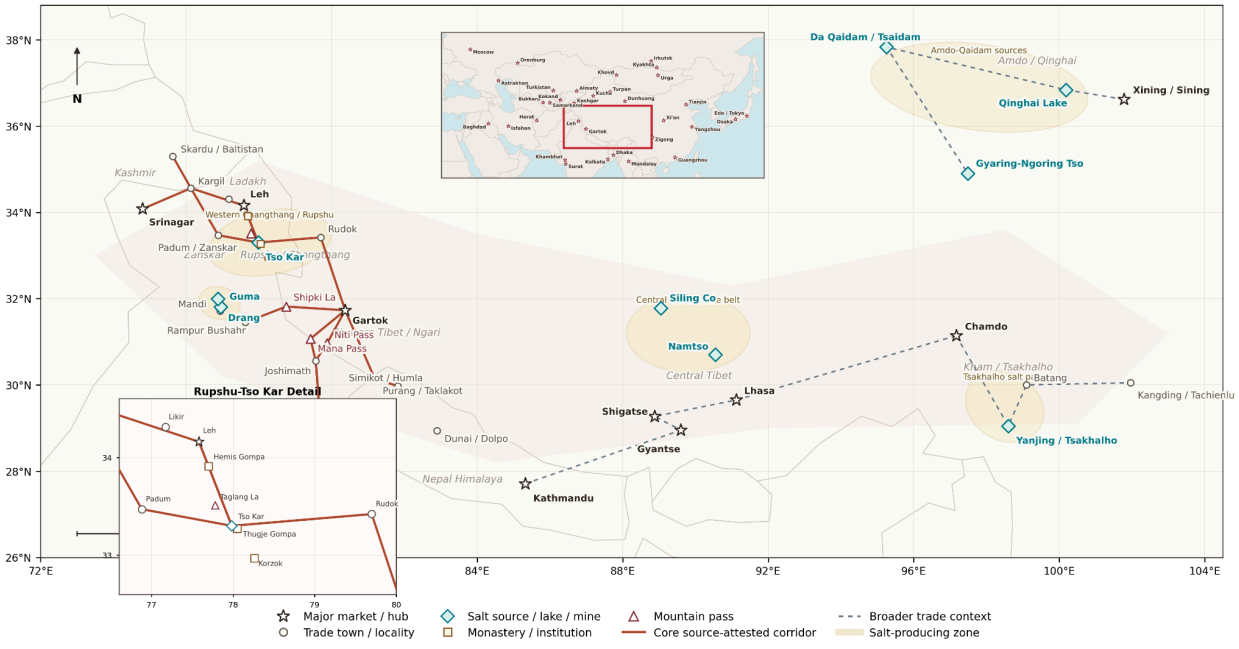
Monasteries and regional political institutions also played an important role in the Himalayan exchange network. Historical scholarship has shown that monasteries frequently operated as centres of redistribution, collecting taxes, receiving tribute, and facilitating the movement of goods across regions. Their influence extended beyond religious practice to encompass economic coordination and local governance. Salt therefore circulated through institutions that simultaneously exercised ritual authority, political legitimacy, and economic influence. Similarly, caravan routes connected not only producers and consumers but also monastic centres, pastoral settlements, and regional polities, creating networks in which mobility, taxation, and political authority intersected. Exchange consequently cannot be separated from the broader institutional landscape within which it occurred.

The environmental conditions of the Western Himalayas further shaped the temporal organisation of exchange. Seasonal migration determined when caravans could travel, when passes remained accessible, and when extraction could occur. Climatic cycles therefore

regulated the rhythm of economic activity, linking production directly to ecological processes (Rizvi, 1995; Ahmed, 1999, p. 41, n. 21). Pastoral mobility, caravans, and salt extraction were interrelated elements of a seasonal cycle instead of separate economic activities.

A recurring theme across the Himalayan literature is that salt functioned simultaneously as an economic resource, a political instrument, and a social institution. Its circulation facilitated not only the movement of commodities but also the reproduction of social relationships, customary rights, and political authority. Thus, research into the area never treats salt as an object of exchange value only. Rather, it is viewed in a broader context of frontier governance, pastoral organisation, mobility, environmental adaptation, and interconnection between regions. These interpretations illustrate ideas advanced by Mauss, Polanyi, Scott, Thompson, and Parthasarathi, demonstrating that exchange in the Himalayan region was embedded into the social and political order long before colonial interventions aimed to govern this social order through taxation, monopoly, licensing, and regulation.

Despite its value, current research has several weaknesses. Much of the literature has focused either on ethnographic accounts of pastoral communities or on descriptive histories of caravan trade and regional commerce. While these studies have substantially enriched understanding of Himalayan exchange, the relationships between commodities, institutions, routes, and political actors often remain dispersed across travel narratives, gazetteers, administrative reports, treaties, and ethnographic observations. It is therefore challenging to examine the Himalayan salt economy as a unified system. This limitation is particularly evident when attempting to reconstruct the wider networks through which salt linked pastoral communities, monasteries, state authorities, frontier markets, and other commodities.



1.5 Conclusion

The literature reviewed in this chapter demonstrates that exchange cannot be understood as a purely economic phenomenon governed solely by market forces. Across anthropology, economic history, and political economy, scholars have consistently challenged the assumption that markets constitute the natural or universal basis of economic organisation. Instead, the works of Marcel Mauss, Karl Polanyi, James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi collectively illustrate that economic life has historically been embedded within wider systems of reciprocity, customary rights, political authority, ecological constraints, and moral obligations. Although these scholars differ in their historical contexts and analytical emphasis, they converge in rejecting market universalism and instead emphasise the social and political institutions through which exchange was organised. Together, they provide an important conceptual framework for examining societies where economic activity cannot be separated from the broader structures of social life.

These theoretical frameworks are particularly useful for comprehending the history of the Himalayan salt economy. Beyond its role as a tradable item, salt played an important part in interrelated systems of pastoral migration, ecological adaption, religious rituals, and local governance. Historical and anthropological research has shown that its distribution was based on reciprocity, caravan arrangements, redistribution by monasteries, customary regulations, and ecological complementarity. Thus, trade in the Western Himalayas operated through social systems that linked people across ecological zones in long-term relationships. Salt emerged not simply as an object of commerce but as a medium through which communities negotiated survival, authority, and interdependence within a geographically fragmented frontier.

At the same time, the reviewed literature indicates that these embedded systems of exchange were neither static nor isolated from wider historical processes. Colonial rule transformed these institutions through taxation, monopolies, licensing, frontier administration, and increasing bureaucratisation. Such transformations did not merely alter patterns of trade; they reshaped the political and social relationships through which exchange had previously been organised. Consequently, the Himalayan salt economy must be understood not only in terms of commodity circulation but also as part of a broader history of state formation, frontier governance, and colonial political economy.

The principal gap, therefore, concerns the reconstruction of connections across commodities, routes, institutions, and political authorities. This study is situated within this historiographical context. Instead of supplanting this historical and anthropological research, this thesis aims to supplement these works by bringing together archival evidence on the Western Himalayan salt trade. In doing so, it uses an interdisciplinary methodology based on historical analysis of archival evidence to explore the interconnections between commodities, routes, institutions and political agents. The objective is not simply to reconstruct individual episodes of trade but to understand the wider networks through which salt shaped frontier economies and political authority during the colonial period. Computational analysis supplements conventional historical analysis by exploring the intricate network of transactions recorded in dispersed archives (Painter et al., 2019).

The following chapter therefore moves from theoretical and historiographical discussions to the historical sources themselves. It examines the principal archival materials including gazetteers, colonial administrative reports, treaties, travel accounts, and Foreign Department records that document the circulation of salt across the Western Himalayas. The archives serve as the empirical base for building historical networks of connections established via the salt trade.

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